Theory: rules made to be broken (Feb 28 2026)

- Music theory is not a set of rules you have to follow. But it's helpful to know some of the patterns that have shown up in music.for centuries!
    - "Music theory" is a description of harmony in the style of 18th century European composers.
        - There is a lot of music that doesn't fit this description, but still sounds good
        - The only "rule" if there is one: "**if it sounds good, it is good**."
    - **In theory we talk about "keys", "chords" and "scales"**
        - Keys are the tonal center of a piece, one for each key on the piano. There are 12 keys, each with seven different chords and scales that sound good around that center
        - Chords are combinations of notes that sound a certain way when played together
            - Major
            - Minor
            - Also diminished and augmented and extended
            - Scales are series of notes that sound good with a given chord
    - **The 7 chords and modes/scales derived from the C major scale**
        - Music in the key of C uses all the white notes starting with C (play **C major scale**).
        - Play the first, third and fifth note of the scale together (demonstrate counting scale steps), that's a C major chord, and it is the *I* chord in the key of C major.
        - Move up, make chords and scales for every scale step.
        - A major/minor pattern emerges

chord	major/minor	mode	in key of C
I	**major**	ionian	C
ii	minor	dorian	Dm
iii	minor	phrygian	Em
IV	**major**	lydian	F
V	**major**	myxolydian	G7
vi	minor	aeolian	Am
vii	diminished	locrian	Bdim

        - The major chords in the key of C are C, F and G, the I, IV and V. These are often the heart of a song
        - Next page: Diatonic harmony demo: *Heart and Soul*

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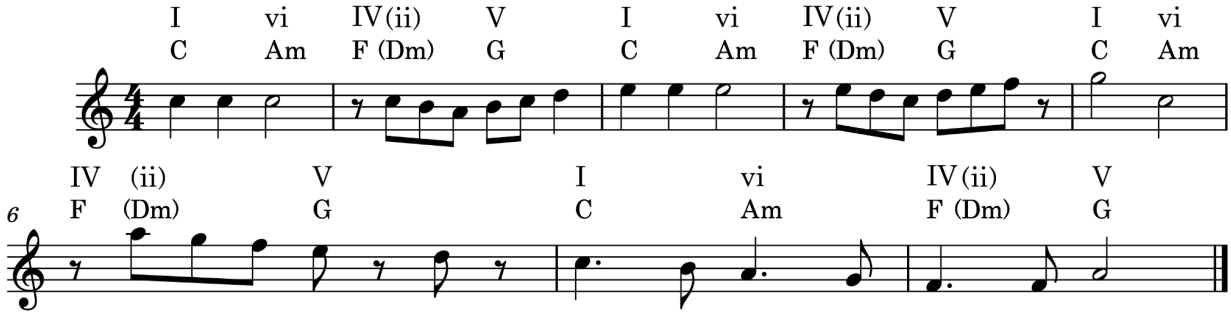
Heart and Soul

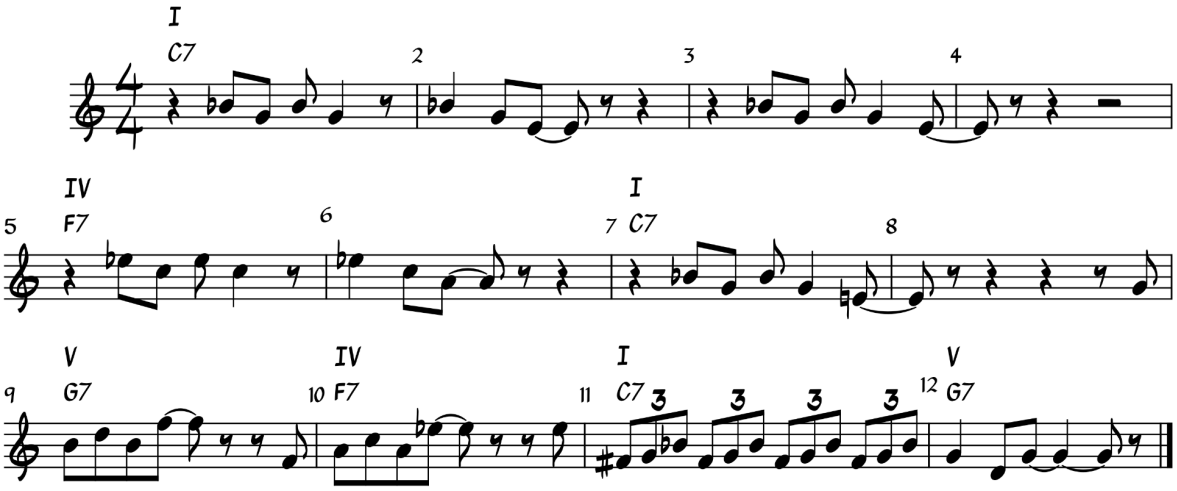


- Chords are I-vi-IV-V or I-vi-ii-V (discuss substitution)
- Melody plays only the notes of the C major scale.
- Try improvising the melody while somebody plays the chords. Do all the white keys work pretty much anywhere in the changes?

○ **Extended harmony with sevenths**

- With I-V-VI in C, we get Cmaj7, Fmaj7 and G7. Demo and discuss difference between Cmaj7 and G7
  - Does the G7 feel unresolved?
  - Does it lead you back to the center of the key, Cmaj7?
- In blues and rock we embrace the suspense of dominant sevenths for all the chords. So we get I7-IV7-V7. (blues harmony demo)

Blues for TJ



- This breaks the rules! But does it sound ok?
- Demo “by the rules”without accidentals. Sounds ok but different?

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